trouble when you start to think: well, maybe they're right. Even when you're the person it's happening to and you actually know that they're wrong. Victoria understood how much playing against Madrid meant to me. She knew why I thought, after the injury at the Bernabeu, I had to play—and play well—at Old Trafford. So Victoria let me talk and then said her bit:

'So you're on the bench. Well, don't forget to take your Preparation H out there with you. You spend more time sitting on that bench than you do playing. Hemorrhoids will be next.' 'Eh?'

'And make sure you keep a smile on your face so, if the camera's on you, nobody will know there's anything wrong.'

We laughed, both of us. She meant what she said. She was telling me just to get on with it, which I knew was what I had to do. But she's the only person in the world who could have said it to me the way she did. Victoria brought me back to the real world. It didn't matter, the day of a game, how I was feeling. What mattered was that the team beat Real Madrid. By the time I got back to Old Trafford, I'd got a lid on the morning's emotions. I got changed, went out for the warm-up with the rest of the lads. Walked round the dressing room, shaking hands and wishing my mates good luck. And then got a sweatshirt on, made my way along the touchline from the tunnel and climbed the flight of stairs to squeeze in alongside the other subs. The seven of us sat tight and watched United start the job of trying to come back from a two-goal deficit against the best team in Europe. We sat and watched. And I waited.

I tried to keep that smile on my face too. Or, at least, keep a frown off it. I knew the cameras would be cutting away to the bench. I knew how much fuss had been made in the media about me being left out. The evening was supposed to be about the game, though. Not about a player falling out with his boss. I didn't want to take the focus away from the players out there. If there was anything to be said, I could say it if I got on. Meantime, it was all about not letting on how sick I was feeling. I wonder if any other game, against any other team, could have made me forget, even for a minute, where I was and what had happened that day. Real Madrid were 3–1 up, in a position they didn't need to take any risks. But they just came at us the same way they had at the Bernabeu, pinging passes about, looking like they were going to score every time they attacked. I was swept away in it along with 67,000 others.

Ronaldo destroyed us. Raul was out with appendicitis, so the big man was on his own up front and Madrid played an extra midfielder, Steve